numerical strength for voting purposes, Iqbal's proposal for Ahmadiyya exclusion seemed to weaken Muslim chances for electoral success.

Above all, however, Nehru questioned the political wisdom of establishing unity within Islam by excluding groups on theological grounds. For lifting economically backward Muslims out of abject poverty, Iqbal's exclusionary measures to cement Islamic solidarity seemed of little to no relief. According to Nehru, Iqbal's arguments could also easily be levelled against several other Islamic sects. Applying the principles of the finality of revelations strictly to all Muslim denominations, for instance, would undoubtedly lead to the exclusion of other groups as well. If connecting revelation to spiritual authority was to be taken as a guideline to restrict the fold of Islam, Nehru presciently analysed, the Aga Khan and his followers, the Ismailis, would have to suffer the same fate that Iqbal had meted out to the Ahmadis.

Nehru found that the Ismaili concept of a perpetual imamate, which entailed the idea of continuous revelation, and their excessive venerating practices of the Aga Khan, made them appear to follow the same Magian thinking Iqbal had identified in the Ahmadis. While teasing the Aga Khan for possessing the curious quality of bridging 'Mecca and Newmarket, this world and the next, spirituality and racing, politics and pleasure', Nehru's main criticism returned to the fact that Muslim solidarity of the Iqbalian variety meshed seamlessly with 'Anglo-Moslem unity'.[27] Despite Iqbal's repeated vows that he wanted to see British imperialism fade, Nehru pointed out that Iqbal was equally comfortable occupying a seat at the 'Council of Peers and Moslem Leaders' that cooperated directly with the British government.[28]

IN JUNE 1936, a year after they had engaged in their public spat on the pages of Indian magazines and newspapers, Iqbal wrote a conciliatory note to Nehru in which he assured him that his responses were 'written with the best of intentions for Islam and India'. Had it not been for the Ahmadi press